

Presenting your work, and being a discussant

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Presenting in Michaelmas (workshops 2, 3, 5)

Short and informal: about five minutes of you, then feedback, twelve minutes in total.

- **Maximum three substantive slides** (one per idea, question or method). PowerPoint or PDF, uploaded to the group OneDrive folder by 8:40 on the morning of the workshop.
- **Slides are a barebones guide** — to keep yourself on track and orient us, not to write down everything you think. Say your thoughts out loud; don't paste in your document.
- **Few words per slide** — you can't read and listen at the same time. Give thought to what we need to know and what you can leave off.
- Try to get across, for each idea: the outcome of interest and a potential explanation, the motivation, and the social and scholarly relevance. You may not have room for all of it; choose.
- From workshop 3 on, **add one slide of specific questions for the group**. Be concrete: "Is V-Dem's civil-liberties index too slow-moving to pick up the change I care about?" beats "any thoughts?"

Presenting in Hilary (workshops 7 and 8)

A 10–12 minute presentation with slides, followed by your discussant (about five minutes), then open discussion.

- Cover the basics — what you are doing and why — but **be as specific as possible**. Show a bit of the data, your survey, a graph of how things look, a first regression table, a case comparison table. Use the slides to your advantage.
- Talk about what is not working: open questions, contingencies if the data do not cooperate, your best guess at exactly how you will analyse things.
- **Circulate a written draft by the Tuesday evening before you present**, at the very latest. The more you send, the better the feedback: an improved and expanded proposal at minimum; a detailed outline is better; an early draft of the introduction and any other sections is best. It does not need to be polished or complete.

Being a discussant

Every student is the assigned discussant for one classmate in Hilary.

- **Read the draft carefully, ahead of time**, and write your comments down and organise them. Plan to speak for about five minutes.
- Lead with what the project is trying to do, in your own words. If you cannot say it in two sentences, that is your first comment.
- Then, constructively: what you did not understand; where clarification would help; the research design worksheet questions that do not yet have clear answers (unit? DV? IV? mechanism? variation? alternatives?); suggestions for the survey, data, cases or analysis; a different way of framing the big picture; and something you liked.
- Be specific and be kind. “The dependent variable seems to include the independent variable — is regime approval part of how you measure legitimacy?” is a good comment. “It’s interesting” is not.

In every workshop

Come with reactions. Ask questions of everyone, not just the person you are discussing. Participation is assessed on substance.